WEEK 7 · LECTURE L2 · UNIT III

Evidence-Based HR and Metrics

What analytics delivers when it works, the traps that stop it, and the difference between a metric, a KPI and a vanity number.

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DSEH001 · Digital Transformation in Human Resource Systems · M.Com. PGCF 2025 · Exam preparation edition

AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

What this lecture prepares you for

- Distinguish data traps from capability traps in HR analytics.
- Distinguish a metric, a KPI and a vanity number.
- Turn a vague HR question into an answerable analytics question.
- Apply LAMP, evidence-based management, the four sources of evidence and the logic model.

COURSE OUTCOMES

CLO 3 and CLO 4 (metrics, KPIs and evidence).

TWO KINDS OF TRAP

Why analytics fails

Data traps	Capability traps
Records split across systems	No owner for analytics
Inconsistent definitions across teams	Reports run, questions never framed
Missing populations: frontline and gig workers	Analysis handed entirely to vendors
Data entered for administration, not analysis	Leaders ask for numbers, not decisions

EXAM LENS

Fixing data without building capability produces cleaner reports that nobody uses.

THREE KINDS OF MEASURE

Metric, KPI and vanity number

Metric

Any measure, for example the number of logins.

KPI

A metric tied to a goal, with an owner and a target: for example, raise frontline active use to 40% by March, owned by regional HR.

Vanity number

Looks good and drives no decision: "90% of staff logged in once" when far fewer use the system regularly.

FROM A VAGUE QUESTION TO AN ANSWER

Making "why are we losing people?" answerable

Element	Specified
Population	All employees in scope, both active and exited
Comparison	Exit rate by manager effectiveness band
Data	Employee manager ratings joined to exit records
Decision	Where to invest in manager coaching

EXAM LENS

Specify population, comparison, data and decision before any analysis. An answer that does this shows rigour.

THEORY IN DEPTH · BOUDREAU AND RAMSTAD (2007)

LAMP: four links that make analytics matter

THE CORE IDEA

Analytics changes decisions only when four elements work together.

HOW IT WORKS

Logic (a causal story), Analytics (sound methods), Measures (valid data), Process (a route into decisions).

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

A framework for diagnosis rather than a tested theory.

IN PRACTICE

An organization that buys an analytics tool supplies only the Analytics link; without logic, trusted measures and a decision process, nothing changes.

EXAM LENS

Use LAMP to diagnose which link is missing in a given case.

THEORY IN DEPTH · PFEFFER AND SUTTON (2006)

Evidence-based management: decide on the best evidence

THE CORE IDEA

Managers often act on habit, imitation and belief rather than evidence.

HOW IT WORKS

Face hard facts, treat the organization as a prototype, look for risks and drawbacks, avoid untested beliefs, update as evidence changes.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Good evidence is often missing in management, so judgment remains necessary.

IN PRACTICE

Faith in a vendor's flight-risk model without testing it is an untested belief.

EXAM LENS

Pair with Briner et al. to show evidence-based practice is broader than "use research".

THEORY IN DEPTH · BRINER, DENYER AND ROUSSEAU (2009)

Evidence comes from four sources

THE CORE IDEA

Evidence-based decisions combine four kinds of evidence, not research alone.

HOW IT WORKS

Practitioner expertise, local organizational data, scientific research, and the values and concerns of those affected.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Weighing the sources against each other has no formula; it takes judgment.

IN PRACTICE

A frontline manager's experience is evidence too, and so are the preferences of the employees affected.

EXAM LENS

Naming all four sources signals a balanced, critical approach.

THEORY IN DEPTH · W. K. KELLOGG FOUNDATION (2004)

The logic model: from inputs to impact

THE CORE IDEA

A program works through a chain: inputs, activities, outputs, outcomes, impact.

HOW IT WORKS

Outputs (courses completed) are not outcomes (skills used), and outcomes are not impact (lower attrition).

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Real programs have feedback loops and delays that the straight chain hides.

IN PRACTICE

Counting course completions measures outputs; a Board cares about outcomes and impact.

EXAM LENS

Use the logic model to classify any HR metric as an output, outcome or impact.

PRACTICE FOR THE END-TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse

"HR analytics fails more often from capability gaps than from data gaps." Discuss using LAMP and evidence-based management. **20 marks**

A strong answer: distinguishes the trap types; applies LAMP; uses Pfeffer and Sutton and Briner et al.; proposes capability building.

Distinguish metrics, KPIs and vanity numbers, and design three KPIs for an HR function, classifying each with the logic model. **20 marks**

A strong answer: gives precise definitions; KPIs with owner, target and counter-metric; correct output, outcome, impact classification.

What are the four sources of evidence in evidence-based management? **10 marks**

A strong answer: names and illustrates all four.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

Three things to remember

1. **Fix capability as well as data, or analytics will not be used**
2. **A KPI has a goal, an owner and a target; a vanity number has none**
3. **Specify population, comparison, data and decision before analyzing**

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

Read for this lecture

- Davenport, T. H., Harris, J., & Shapiro, J. (2010). Competing on talent analytics. *Harvard Business Review, 88*(10), 52–58.

COMPANION

Each set reading is explained in the matching Unit Reader on rksingh.tech/materials.

THEORY SOURCES · FOR REFERENCE

Sources for this lecture

Works named on the slides of this lecture. They are background sources, not set readings.

Boudreau, J. W., & Ramstad, P. M. (2007). *Beyond HR: The new science of human capital*. Harvard Business School Press.

Briner, R. B., Denyer, D., & Rousseau, D. M. (2009). Evidence-based management: Concept cleanup time? *Academy of Management Perspectives, 23*(4), 19–32. https://doi.org/10.5465/amp.2009.45590138

Davenport, T. H., Harris, J., & Shapiro, J. (2010). Competing on talent analytics. *Harvard Business Review, 88*(10), 52–58.

Pfeffer, J., & Sutton, R. I. (2006). *Hard facts, dangerous half-truths, and total nonsense: Profiting from evidence-based management*. Harvard Business School Press.

W. K. Kellogg Foundation. (2004). *Logic model development guide*. W. K. Kellogg Foundation.